

SIPRA DAS



The Damascus Deal

DELHI Diplomacy is often about tightrope walking. As India rolled out the red carpet for Syrian President Bashar Al-Assad on June 17, the compulsions to woo its Left allies weighed heavily on Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. The big deliverable from Assad's five-day visit was to flaunt UPA's credentials of having an independent foreign policy.

The 41-year-old ophthalmologist-turned-politician's visit assumes significance as it comes

after five years of being put on cold storage. Earlier, Delhi had not wanted to disturb its own strategic arithmetic with the US, especially in the season of the nuclear deal. India adopted a hands-off approach towards Damascus given Syria's dodgy nuclear programme, its controversial role in Lebanon and its support to Hamas and Hezbollah. It would hardly have been prudent to be seen courting a country that has often been

HOLDING THE KEY: Assad accused of supporting terrorist groups in the Middle East.

Besides a joint declaration expected during Assad's visit, there are three agreements on investment protection and double taxation avoidance lined up. The president is expected to seek a greater role for India to ensure stability in the Middle East.

In turn, Delhi is likely to ask for a bigger chunk of Syria's under-tapped oil exploration blocks, where ONGC Videsh picked up a small stake last year. Bilateral trade is worth just \$750 million with India expected to offer cooperation in IT and pharmaceuticals. However, the visit is expected to come as a driver for the trade figures.

Even though he is at the top of the hit list of the US and the Israelis, the Syrian president holds the key to the Middle East solution with his influence in the four major conflict zones—Lebanon, Israel-Palestine, Iraq and Iran.

by Saurabh Shukla

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: S. Ramachander, 63, former director of the Institute for Financial Management and Research. He was also a theatre personality, corporate strategy consultant and a prolific writer.



APPOINTED: Actor and social activist **Shabana Azmi** as SAARC's goodwill ambassador

for HIV and AIDS programme for its member countries.

DIED: Baldev Singh Khiala, former minister and a leader of Akali Dal 1920. He was the panchayat and rural development minister in the Surjit Singh Barnala-led government in 1986, and represented Punjab's Joga assembly constituency four times.

DIED: Veteran CPI leader **J. Chitharanjan**, 83. He was a former Rajya Sabha member, a former minister of state and was elected to the Kerala Assembly three times.

VIS-A-VIS A.B. BARDHAN CPI general secretary versus RAJNATH SINGH BJP president

“
The (Indo-US) nuclear deal is an attempt to make India a United States' outpost against China.
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SAURABH SINGH

“
The CPI has forgotten that it's an Indian party. They're more concerned about protecting China's interests than our own national interests.
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EPILOGUE: Deal or no deal, we can't talk of national interest without keeping in mind international interest.